

IMPACTING INDIA THROUGH EDUCATION

Excerpts of an interview with Dr. S. B. Mujumdar & Dr. Vidya Yeravdekar

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Having dedicated more than half of his life to the cause of education as a medium to promote international understanding, Dr. Mujumdar has witnessed the evolution of education in India. Mention the Indian education system to him and he asks, "Bharat Mata swatantra hui 1947 mein, Lakshmi swatantra hui 1991 mein, par Saraswati ko swatantrata kab milegi?"

Over the past several decades, government policies and attitudes towards education have been changing, believes Dr. Mujumdar. "It's heartening to see the new Human Resource Development Minister, Kapil Sibal take progressive steps to free education from the shackles of various controlling bodies and create one-window clearance for all types of educational institutions. This Independence Day, I hope that under the leadership of Sibal, education will finally get its due."

In spite of success stories like Symbiosis, education in India has failed to percolate to all corners of the country. Yet, there are positive signs like the 'Right to Education' Bill, says Dr. Mujumdar. "The Bill, though historical, has been pending since 1951. I believe quality higher education can add value only when there is quality education downwards. Education entails three major factors – expansion, inclusion and excellence. Expansion and quality are not at loggerheads – they go hand-in-hand. This is precisely the reason why our focus should be on a huge national programme that aims at producing good teachers."

"Once this Bill becomes an Act, it is up to the State Governments to implement it."

They are the ones who must take initiative and realize that most of our graduates today are unemployed because they are unemployable. Thankfully, the Manmohan Singh government has initiated the concepts of National Skill Development Corporation (NSDC) and 'Community Colleges.' Here, the focus will be on creating skilled manpower. This is the only way to increase employment – because the truth is that, jobs are available, but the right people to do these jobs are not available," explains Dr. Mujumdar.

"There is a strong need for Private Public Partnership at every level. Best practices from private players need to be incorporated. For instance, Distance Education today is a strong alternative system of education. In a large nation like India, e-learning and distance learning need to be treated as a parallel and not as the last resort. Also, a concept like 'Examination on demand' is a boon for so many today."

All of the above factors come and converge at one point – creating 'Knowledge Managers' and not just 'Business Managers' through value-based learning. According to Dr. Mujumdar, "Humanities, Sociology and other such subjects inculcate qualities of leadership – leaders have to be knowledgeable in different fields. Leaders of tomorrow have to be tolerant towards other cultures and opposing views and liberal arts facilitate this."

"When I'm alone, I often look back at the contribution made by our organization to education and there's one factor that strikes me the most – Symbiosis is probably the only educational institution that did not start with the intention of being one. It started with the quality of compassion. That one incident had evoked this compassion in me, when, way back in 1969, I saw a Mauritian student suffering from jaundice and his sister, helping him by sneaking in food through the window. That was when I realized how important it was to provide a home away from home for these foreign students. And education is the best medium to promote international understanding and that was my aim – to make these students unofficial ambassadors of goodwill, back in their own countries. That is the vision with which I had established what today is called Symbiosis International University."

"Simultaneously, I realized that globalization of economy alone is dangerous without globalization of education and therefore globalization of minds. I discovered the fact that 'Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam' (the world is one family) is achievable only through universalization of education. Symbiosis is then, knowingly or unknowingly, accomplishing this - when students from over seventy countries live together and understand through conglomerations, they become world citizens. Technology has done half the job – the remaining half universities like us have to complete."

As a final word, this great stalwart concludes, "Rabindranath Tagore gave us 'Vishwabharti'45. Sane Guruji gave us 'Antarbharti'. The confluence of 'Vishwabharti' and 'Antarbharti' is Symbiosis."

TOWARDS INTERNATIONALIZATION OF HIGHER EDUCATION

Dr. Vidya Yeravdekar

"With students from over seventy countries, Symbiosis is truly an international university. While we have initiated numerous services for our international students like streamlining the entire process of admission through a separate office for them, we have also initiated collaborations with top universities from across the world. The idea is to promote a bilateral student and faculty exchange through joint degree programmes."

"We have initiated numerous events for our international students where they get glimpses of cultures from across the globe through food festivals, dance festivals and various other activities. Our foreign students, along with their Indian counterparts, also undertake blood donation on July 31st, which is International Students' Day. Through our 'Study India Programme', students from Europe, Britain and the United States experience India over a period of 4-6 weeks."

"As a member of the University Grants Commission and PIHEAD (Promotion of Higher Indian Education Abroad), my interests lie in Private Public Partnerships and internationalization of Indian higher education. Today Symbiosis is a NAAC 'A' accredited university. My dream is to secure Symbiosis' place in the top 10 universities of Asia."



Dr. S.B. Mujumdar, Founder Director, Symbiosis Society & Dr. Vidya Yeravdekar, Principal Director, Symbiosis Society